of next week to collect the fuel. Make sure it's ready."

"Yes, Weinführer Brucker." Édouard's voice fell flat as if all the life had been sucked out of it.

Léa didn't dare move again until she heard an engine outside clatter to a start and drive away.

"What was that all about?" she asked, finally stepping into the open.

"You heard us?" he said.

"You aren't making wine but fuel for the German army?"

"Weinführer Brucker's orders." Édouard did not meet her eye.

"Who is—"

"He manages the Loiret wine region and has the power to decide our production." Édouard sat on the stool, hands on his thighs, casting a despairing gaze over the vats. "Some winegrowers only have half of their production requisitioned, but he *steals* all of mine." His face hardened.

"Surely he pays you for making fuel."

He shook his head. "Requisitioning production for the German Wehrmacht is always without compensation."

Léa wished she could do something to help. "What did he pour in the vats?"

"Heating oil. The wine is ruined."

She drew back, her cheeks burning with anger. She'd mistakenly lulled herself into believing the farmhouse could be a safe harbor to ride out the war. The reality was that everyone faced trouble, whether in the city or the countryside. It was the first time she understood the extra burden she and Rose placed on Édouard and Virginie by being here. "Rose and I shouldn't be here. We're a burden you can't—"

"No," he said, standing. "Virginie and I are grateful for your presence and help. With André gone, we wouldn't be able to make the fuel without your labor, not to mention the wonderful companionship Rose provides for Paulette." He smiled, seemingly wanting to reassure her. "You mustn't worry. I knew this day was coming. I have a plan. Everything will work out." He took a breath. "Don't say anything to Paulette or Rose; they're both too young to understand. I'll tell Virginie later." He tilted his head toward the window, and sunlight flickered across his face. "Do you understand?"

Léa nodded, though doubt churned inside her. She couldn't imagine